

How to Write a Brand Brief

A structured template for briefing a brand agency — the document that separates projects that run well from projects that don't.

How to Write a Brand Brief

A brand brief is the document that aligns the client and the agency on what's being built, why it's being built, and how success will be defined. A good brief makes great creative more likely. A poor brief makes it almost impossible. Here's how to write one.

■ Company overview

Start with a concise description of the company that a well-informed outsider could understand — not the investor pitch version, but the honest one.

- ☐ What does the company actually do, in plain language?
 - ☐ What's the current stage of growth (pre-revenue, growth, enterprise)?
 - ☐ What markets does it operate in?
 - ☐ What are the most significant things that have happened in the last 12 months?
 - ☐ What's planned for the next 12–24 months that the brand needs to support?
-

■ The brand project

Define exactly what you're commissioning — scope, not just intent.

- ☐ What are the specific deliverables you need?
 - ☐ What is the reason you need them (pivoting, launching, refreshing, rebranding)?
 - ☐ What is the project start date and launch deadline?
 - ☐ What is the total budget range for the project?
 - ☐ Who are the internal stakeholders and who has final approval authority?
-

■ Target audience

Don't just list demographics. Describe the person you're trying to reach — their motivations, fears, how they make decisions, and what they currently think about your category.

- ☐ Primary audience: who is the most important person the brand needs to reach?
 - ☐ Secondary audiences (investors, employees, partners, press)
 - ☐ What does your primary audience currently believe about your company or category?
 - ☐ What do you want them to believe after encountering your brand?
 - ☐ What are their primary objections to buying/choosing you?
-

| Brand positioning

If you have an existing positioning, share it. If you don't, answer these questions as accurately as you can.

- ☐ What is the one thing you want to be famous for?
 - ☐ What do you do better than anyone else?
 - ☐ Why should your target audience choose you over the alternatives?
 - ☐ What are the top 3 things your brand should communicate?
 - ☐ What should your brand never be associated with?
-

| Competitive landscape

Name your primary competitors and be honest about their strengths and weaknesses.

- ☐ List your 3–5 primary competitors
 - ☐ Share examples of their visual and verbal identity
 - ☐ What do they do well that you respect?
 - ☐ Where do they fall short?
 - ☐ What visual or verbal territory do they dominate that you need to navigate around?
-

| Visual references

Share examples of brands, in or outside your category, that you admire — and crucially, why you admire them.

- ☐ 3–5 brands whose identity you admire (with explanation of what works)
 - ☐ 3–5 visual references that evoke the feeling the brand should have
 - ☐ Any visual elements you specifically want to avoid
 - ☐ Any existing brand elements that must be retained
-

| Mandatories and constraints

Every project has constraints. Document them clearly so they're not discovered halfway through.

- ☐ Legal or regulatory constraints on brand communications
 - ☐ Existing brand elements that cannot change (colours, marks, etc.)
 - ☐ Technical constraints (the identity must work within a specific platform)
 - ☐ Internal political constraints (elements that have significant internal attachment)
 - ☐ Territory or language requirements
-